



Figure 6: Use the configuration editor to relocate window buttons

For multi-core/multi-processor systems, you should add one applet per core to the panel, and choose the relevant CPU in each applet's *Preferences*.

You can change the processor/core speed by clicking the applet. You can choose *Performance* when doing 'heavy' tasks like watching videos or copying big files. Geeky fun! However, this could consume more power, and heat up the processor (reducing battery life, and the overall life of your system). A good choice is *OnDemand*, which lets Linux auto-boost your CPU speed when it needs more processing power, and drop back to minimum speed afterwards—a good balance between performance and power-saving, extending the battery life and cool running.

Label your partitions

The Nautilus file manager labels partitions as '10 GB filesystem', '150 GB filesystem' and so on, which can be perplexing. Give them sensible labels like 'Backups', 'Movies', whatever. From the main menu, head to *System > Administration > Disk Utility*. Select *Hard Disk*. Select the partition you'd like to label; check that the partition is unmounted first, then click *Edit Filesystem Label* (see Figure 4).

Enable useful Compiz effects

Ah, Compiz! Who doesn't love Compiz for eye-candy? Now you'll love it for its usefulness. First, install the *Simple CompizConfig Settings Manager* by searching for 'simple ccs' in the Software Centre. Launch Simple CCSM, and click the *Effects* tab. Enable the *Expo* and *Scale* effects. Now click the *Desktop* tab. If you don't need the Ubuntu-default four desktops, reduce *Desktop Columns* to two; this will save memory. Now click the *Edges* tab. You'll see the image of a computer screen. Click one of its red-coloured edges. A large pop-up menu will appear; select '*Scale: initiate window picker for all windows.*' Now, when you move the mouse pointer to the chosen edge, your windows conveniently arrange themselves (see Figure 5). I use this as an alternative to *Alt+Tab* for switching between applications. Assign actions to other edges if you like! Your left edge could be the window picker and the right could be *Expo*, for instance. And oh—at any time, press *Esc* to return to the desktop!

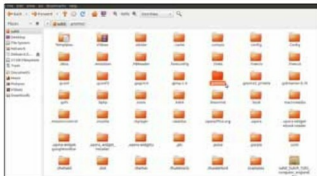


Figure 7: Home folder with hidden folders un-hidden

Move window buttons from left to right

Why do Americans drive on the right? Why does Ubuntu put the close, minimise and maximise buttons on the left? Shift the buttons to the right if you like them the old way. Press *Alt+F2* for the *Run Application* window, or better, use *Synapse*! Type *gconf-editor* as the command to run, and press *Enter*. Navigate to *apps > metacity > general*. Change the *button_layout* option to '*menu: minimize, maximize, close*' (no spaces between commas!) as seen in Figure 6. Hit *Enter*.

Enhance Nautilus with Nautilus scripts

You can install third-party scripts that add functionality to Nautilus' right-click menu. First, head to www.gnome-look.org and navigate to the Nautilus scripts page. There, you have hundreds of scripts. I recommend that you at least get 'Send to', 'Send link to Desktop', 'Backup' and any of the 'Rename multiple files' scripts. There are also scripts that can convert multimedia files, download pictures from a camera, upload to Facebook, Gmail or Flickr, burn a disc... and remember, each functionality is available by just right-clicking one or more files or folders. Beat that, Windows!

Extract the downloaded scripts, and copy them to your *.gnome2/nautilus-scripts* folder. Note that this is a hidden folder. Navigate to your home folder, and press *Ctrl+H* to make hidden folders visible (and the same key combination to hide them again when done). Navigate into *.gnome2/nautilus-scripts* and paste the copied scripts.

There are hundreds of possible tips and tweaks for your Ubuntu desktop. I have covered a few that will speed up your work-flow. There are many websites that deal with customising your GNU/Linux desktop, both for utility and cosmetics. You'll realise that your desktop is truly yours—an expression of individuality. That freedom is only available in the free-software world. 

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